



Generative Artificial Intelligence and Research Integrity: A Responsibility-Centred Framework

Inteligência Artificial Generativa e Integridade na Investigação: Um Modelo Centrado na Responsabilidade

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Abstract

Generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) is increasingly integrated into academic writing, research workflows, and editorial processes, raising fundamental ethical and governance concerns for scholarly publishing. This paper presents an integrative narrative review and conceptual synthesis of a large interdisciplinary corpus of Scopus-indexed literature on AI in academic research, publishing ethics, and editorial decision-making. The study pursues three interrelated aims: to clarify the ethical challenges associated with GenAI across research, peer review, and editorial decision-making; to systematise AI-assisted scholarly practices by distinguishing among integrity-compromising uses, ethically responsible uses, and persistent grey zones in which norms remain contested; and to develop a human-centred, context-sensitive governance perspective to guide authors, reviewers, and editors. The analysis identifies human epistemic responsibility as the central ethical concern, showing that risks arise not from AI itself but from the displacement or obscuring of accountable scholarly judgment. The study contributes a framework for the responsible integration of GenAI into scholarly research and publishing.

Keywords: Generative Artificial Intelligence, Research Integrity, Academic Publishing, Epistemic Responsibility, AI ethics, Editorial Governance.

Resumo

A inteligência artificial generativa (GenAI) está a ser cada vez mais integrada na escrita académica, nos fluxos de trabalho de investigação e nos processos editoriais, levantando questões éticas e de governação fundamentais para a publicação científica. Este artigo apresenta uma revisão narrativa integrativa e uma síntese conceptual de um corpus interdisciplinar de literatura indexada na Scopus sobre IA na investigação académica, ética nas publicações e tomada de decisão editorial. O estudo tem três objetivos: clarificar os desafios éticos associados à GenAI ao longo da investigação, da revisão por pares e da tomada de decisão editorial; sistematizar as práticas académicas assistidas por IA, distinguindo entre usos que comprometem a integridade, usos eticamente responsáveis e zonas cinzentas persistentes em que as normas permanecem contestadas; e desenvolver uma perspetiva de governação centrada na inteligência humana para orientar autores, revisores e editores. A análise identifica a responsabilidade epistémica humana como a preocupação ética central, mostrando que os riscos decorrem do deslocamento ou obscurecimento do decisão académica responsável. O estudo contribui com um quadro para a integração responsável da GenAI na investigação e na publicação científicas.

Palavras-chave: Inteligência Artificial Generativa; Integridade na Investigação; Publicação Académica; Responsabilidade Epistémica; Ética da IA; Governação Editorial.

1. Introduction

GenAI has rapidly become embedded in all areas of human activity, including academic research (Fang, Feng & Tian, 2025). Tools capable of producing fluent scholarly text, summarising literature, generating code, and assisting with analysis are now widely accessible to researchers across disciplines. While these developments offer potential benefits in terms of efficiency, accessibility, and support, they also raise deep ethical and epistemic questions for scholarly publishing (Dwivedi et al., 2023; Gendron, Andrew & Cooper, 2022; Lund et al., 2023; Misra & Chandwar, 2023).

Early responses to GenAI in academic publishing have focused primarily on technical and procedural concerns, including plagiarism detection, authorship attribution, and disclosure requirements. Many journals and established publishers, such as Emerald, Elsevier, Nature Portfolio, SAGE, Taylor & Francis, and Wiley, have issued rapid policy statements clarifying that AI systems cannot be listed as authors and that their use should be transparently declared (Ganjavi et al., 2024; Lund & Naheem, 2023; Yin, Wang &



Zhou, 2025). Although these measures represent important first steps in establishing baseline norms, a growing body of recent literature suggests that compliance-based approaches alone are insufficient to address the deeper epistemic, ethical, and governance challenges posed by AI-assisted scholarship (Ferrell et al., 2024; Ganjavi et al., 2024; Kousha & Thelwall, 2023; Dwivedi et al., 2023).

At the core of these challenges lies a fundamental mismatch between automation and responsibility. GenAI systems are being increasingly used for drafting arguments, synthesising sources, and shaping analytical structures, yet they lack moral agency and cannot be held accountable for errors, bias, or misrepresentation (Floridi et al., 2018; Mittelstadt et al., 2016; Coeckelbergh, 2020). This creates a risk that intellectual responsibility becomes blurred or displaced, particularly when AI assistance extends beyond surface-level language support into reasoning, interpretation, or theory construction (Coeckelbergh, 2020; Dwivedi et al., 2023; Moffatt & Hall, 2025; Moorhouse, Kohnke & Walsh, 2025). Concerns have also been raised about fabricated references, synthetic plagiarism, automation bias in peer review, and the emergence of AI-enabled paper mills, all of which threaten the reliability and trustworthiness of academic research (Al Barajraji et al., 2024; Guleria et al., 2023; van Dis et al., 2023).

Despite the growing volume of literature on these issues, existing research remains fragmented. Much of the literature addresses AI ethics in isolation from editorial governance, or focuses narrowly on author behaviour without adequately considering the roles of reviewers, editors, and publishers as ethical gatekeepers (Ateriya et al., 2025; Dwivedi et al., 2023; Kocak, 2023; Lund et al., 2023; van Dis et al., 2023). Moreover, existing research has paid limited attention to how disciplinary epistemologies shape the ethical evaluation of AI use, despite clear evidence that the implications of AI-assisted practices differ markedly across research fields (Gendron et al., 2022; Misra & Chandwar, 2023; Moorhouse et al., 2025). As a result, authors, reviewers, and editors often lack coherent, context-sensitive guidance for managing AI-related ethical dilemmas in practice.

This paper addresses these gaps by asking the following research question: How can the ethical challenges posed by GenAI in academic research be systematically understood and governed in ways that preserve research integrity and human responsibility? To answer this question, the study pursues the following three interrelated aims: i) To clarify the ethical challenges associated with GenAI across research, peer review, and editorial decision-making; ii) To systematise AI-assisted scholarly practices by distinguishing between unethical practices, ethical and responsible uses, and persistent grey zones, thereby developing a differentiated conceptual framework that moves beyond binary or compliance-based evaluations; iii) To develop a human-centred and context-sensitive governance perspective capable of guiding authors, reviewers, and editors in making informed, proportionate, and ethically grounded decisions regarding the use of GenAI in academic research.

The paper adopts an integrative narrative review and conceptual synthesis approach, and contributes a holistic framework that connects ethical theory, editorial practice, and disciplinary context. In doing so, it responds to the practical need for guidance in a rapidly evolving publishing environment and contributes to advancing theoretical understanding of responsibility, accountability, and governance on the use of AI in academic research. The ultimate aim is to support the responsible integration of GenAI into scholarly publishing, promoting trust, transparency, and integrity.

2. Contextual Framework

2.1 GenAI in Academic Writing and Research Practices

A substantial body of recent literature documents the rapid uptake of GenAI tools in academic writing and research workflows. Empirical studies and reviews consistently show that AI is primarily used for language-related support, including grammar correction, paraphrasing, summarising, drafting preliminary text, and improving readability (Pereira et al., 2024; Shimray & Subaveerapandiyam, 2025). These practices are often framed as productivity-enhancing and particularly beneficial for early-career researchers and non-native English speakers, who may otherwise face linguistic barriers that constrain their publication in international journals (Li et al., 2024; Zu, 2025).

Beyond surface-level editing, some studies describe more advanced uses of AI, such as supporting literature exploration, structuring arguments, and assisting with data management and analysis (Khalifa & Albadawy, 2024; Kousha & Thelwall, 2023; Madanchian & Taherdoost, 2025). However, the literature repeatedly alerts that these capabilities distort the boundary between assistance and intellectual contribution. The use of AI systems to generate substantive content or analytical structures raises questions about authorship, originality, and the allocation of scholarly judgment and epistemic authority (Lund et al., 2023; Lund & Naheem, 2023; Moffatt & Hall, 2025).

Several authors emphasise that writing in academia is not merely a technical activity but a core epistemic practice through which reasoning, interpretation, and theory construction occur (Moorhouse et al., 2025). From this perspective, extensive reliance on GenAI risks encouraging superficial engagement with sources and standard argumentation, particularly in fields where interpretive depth and contextual sensitivity are central to knowledge production.



2.2 Research Integrity, Misconduct, and Ethical Concerns

Concerns have also been raised about fabricated references, synthetic plagiarism, automation bias in peer review, and the uncritical reproduction of existing knowledge structures, all of which threaten the reliability and traceability of scholarly claims, particularly when AI-generated content is not independently verified by authors (Ateriya et al., 2025; Guleria et al., 2023; Jain, Nimonkar, & Jadhav, 2025; Cohen, 2025).

Some studies highlight the emergence of automated and AI-assisted forms of misconduct that scale and normalise fraudulent publishing practices, thereby exploiting vulnerabilities in peer review and editorial screening processes (Al Barajraji et al., 2024; Mainous, 2025). In this context, GenAI may act as an accelerant of pre-existing structural problems within performance-driven academic systems, including publication pressure, metric-based evaluation, and the increasing automation of scholarly workflows (França & Monserrat, 2024; Gendron et al., 2022; Lund & Naheem, 2023).

A significant contribution of this literature is the distinction between unethical practices and problematic, yet non-malicious, uses of AI. Deliberate non-disclosure, intentional substitution of scholarly judgment, fabrication of content, and the generation of unverifiable references are widely framed as forms of research misconduct or serious violations of research integrity (Guleria et al., 2023; Lund & Naheem, 2023; Misra & Chandwar, 2023; Pereira et al., 2024). By contrast, good-faith but poorly governed uses of AI, such as uncritical reliance on AI-generated summaries or inadequate disclosure, are often treated as matters requiring education, clearer guidance, and proportionate editorial responses rather than sanction alone (Kousha & Thelwall, 2023; Moorhouse et al., 2025; França & Monserrat, 2024).

2.3 Editorial Governance, Policy Responses, and Disciplinary Sensitivity

A growing body of literature analyses how journals, publishers, and scholarly organisations are responding to GenAI through policy development. Comparative reviews show increasing convergence around a small set of principles: AI systems cannot be listed as authors; responsibility for all content rests with human authors; and the use of AI should be transparently disclosed (Lund & Naheem, 2023; Ganjavi et al., 2024; Yin et al., 2025).

This convergence, however, is not only reflected in publisher-level policies but also grounded in a broader normative and reporting landscape that has progressively clarified the baseline expectations governing AI use in scholarly work. As shown in Table 1, the main international frameworks converge on three core principles: rejection of AI authorship, preservation of human accountability, and transparency when AI materially affects scholarly content.

Table 1. Cross-cutting frameworks shaping editorial responses to AI

Reference framework	Main contribution to AI governance in scholarly publishing	Analytical relevance
Committee on Publication Ethics (COPE)	States that AI tools cannot be authors because they cannot assume responsibility for the work; emphasises transparency, human oversight, and accountability in the use of AI tools	Establishes the ethical baseline that underpins later publisher and journal policies
World Association of Medical Editors (WAME)	Holds that chatbots and GenAI cannot qualify as authors; requires proper acknowledgement of their use; stresses that human authors must take public responsibility for the content and that editors need to protect editorial integrity	Clarifies how AI use intersects with authorship, attribution, and editorial practice
International Committee of Medical Journal Editors (ICMJE)	Requires disclosure of AI-assisted technologies at submission, prohibits listing AI as an author, and places responsibility for accuracy, integrity, originality, attribution, and absence of plagiarism on human authors	Connects AI use to manuscript submission standards and author responsibility
American Psychological Association (APA)	Provides guidance on how to document and cite GenAI when it is materially relevant to the work, rather than determining whether its use is ethically permissible	Contributes to the formal traceability of AI use within the scholarly record

Source: own elaboration.

These frameworks establish the ethical baseline upon which later publisher and journal policies are built, providing a common point of departure for defining which forms of AI assistance may be considered acceptable, which uses remain incompatible with scholarly integrity, and what kind of disclosure is expected in practice.



Beyond these shared principles, however, editorial policies diverge substantially in the way they operationalise them. Some adopt restrictive approaches that limit AI use to language editing, proofreading, or other supportive functions, while others permit broader applications provided that disclosure, verification, and human accountability are maintained (Misra & Chandwar, 2023; Moorhouse et al., 2025). Table 2 summarises these differences by comparing how selected publishers and journals define acceptable uses of AI, prohibited practices, and disclosure requirements in contemporary scholarly communication.

Table 2. Comparative editorial positions on acceptable AI use in scholarly publishing

Publisher	Policy stance	AI may be used for...	AI may not be used for...	Required condition
Elsevier	Conditional acceptance	Supporting manuscript preparation, including literature synthesis, idea generation, content organisation, and language improvement	Replacing human critical thinking or expertise, or being credited as an author	GenAI use must be disclosed, and authors must verify accuracy, impartiality, sources, privacy, and intellectual property compliance
Emerald	Restrictive acceptance	Editing, refining, and improving the author’s own original text	Drafting new manuscript content or being credited with authorship	Authors must describe the content created or modified and identify the AI tool used
SAGE	Differentiated approach	Assistive uses and some generative uses, such as literature support, translation, code checking, or data visualisation	Uses that compromise peer review, editorial confidentiality, analytical validity, image originality, or citation reliability	Substantive AI-generated content must be disclosed, and authors must verify all outputs and original sources
Springer Nature	Precautionary approach	Use under general responsible-use principles and editorial guidance	Being credited with authorship, generating images for publication, or uploading manuscripts into GenAI tools during peer review	AI use must remain consistent with editorial policy and confidentiality safeguards
Taylor & Francis	Broad but delimited responsible-use approach	Idea generation, language improvement, search, literature classification, and coding assistance	Replacing core researcher responsibilities; generating certain images, figures, or original research data; or use in peer review that breaches confidentiality	Authors must clearly acknowledge the tool, version, purpose, and reason for use
Wiley	Guided responsible-use approach	Supporting writing and research preparation as a companion tool	Replacing authorship, accountability, originality, or intellectual leadership	Authors must disclose AI use, document how it was used, and verify outputs for accuracy, bias, privacy, and rights protection

Source: authors’ own elaboration based on Elsevier (n.d.); Emerald Publishing (2023); Sage Publishing (n.d.); Springer Nature (n.d.); Taylor & Francis (n.d.); and Wiley (n.d.).

The comparison reveals that the principal differences do not lie in the overall normative direction of these policies, since none recognises AI as an authorial entity and all preserve human responsibility for manuscript integrity. Rather, the variation lies in the editorial stance adopted toward acceptable AI use, particularly in relation to the scope of permitted assistance, the degree of precaution applied to generative functions, and the specificity with which disclosure and verification duties are articulated. More restrictive policies, such as those of Emerald Publishing, confine AI to limited supportive uses and explicitly reject its role in drafting article text, whereas others, including Elsevier, Wiley, and Taylor & Francis, allow a broader range of uses provided that human oversight remains fully in place.

Several studies have also noted that policies often fail to keep pace with practice, leaving editors to rely on discretionary judgment when evaluating manuscripts involving AI use and making decisions in the absence of clear implementation guidance (Ganjavi et al., 2024). This becomes particularly important in areas where AI use intersects with peer review confidentiality, image generation, analytical validity, citation reliability, or the delegation of core interpretive tasks. In such cases, editorial governance extends beyond disclosure alone and increasingly concerns the broader integrity of the publication process.

A recurring theme in the literature is scepticism toward over-reliance on AI detection tools and quantitative indicators. While such tools may assist in preliminary screening, they are widely regarded as insufficient for determining ethical acceptability, epistemic quality, or responsible authorship (Doskaliuk et al., 2025; Gendron et al., 2022; Kousha & Thelwall, 2023; Lund & Naheem, 2023).



Editorial governance is therefore increasingly conceptualised as a qualitative, context-sensitive practice grounded in human judgement rather than a purely technical or compliance-driven process.

This context-sensitive dimension becomes especially visible in fields such as tourism and hospitality research. Editorial reflections from these areas illustrate that AI governance is shaped not only by general ethical principles but also by disciplinary epistemologies, methodological pluralism, and the close interconnections between empirical analysis, interpretation, and theory development (Dogru et al., 2023; Assaf et al., 2025). In such settings, editorial concern extends beyond whether AI has been used to how it may have influenced the framing of research problems, the interpretation of evidence, and the traceability of scholarly judgement.

From this perspective, what matters is not merely the presence of AI assistance, but its epistemic impact on scholarly work and the extent to which human authors, reviewers, and editors remain able to justify, interpret, and assume responsibility for the claims being advanced. A broader conclusion emerges: the governance of GenAI in scholarly publishing cannot rely on one-size-fits-all prescriptions, but requires context-sensitive editorial judgement that remains attentive to the epistemic demands of different fields while consistently reaffirming the non-delegable nature of human responsibility.

2.4 Human–AI Complementarity and Epistemic Responsibility

Underlying these editorial and disciplinary debates is a dominant conceptual framing across the literature that positions GenAI as a complementary tool rather than an autonomous agent. From this perspective, AI may enhance efficiency, accessibility, and exploratory support in academic work. Still, it does not possess the moral agency, contextual understanding, or epistemic responsibility required to assume authorship, interpretation, or accountable scholarly judgement (Buitrago-Esquinas et al., 2024; Ferrell et al., 2024; Samuel, Chubb & Derrick, 2021). Recent empirical work comparing AI-generated and human-authored texts reinforces this view. Although AI-generated writing may achieve high levels of readability, fluency, and surface coherence, it is often perceived as lacking depth, originality, and experiential grounding when compared with human writing (Amirjalili, Neysani, & Nikbakht, 2024; Tengler & Brandhofer, 2025). These findings support the argument that human oversight should not be understood merely as a procedural safeguard added after the fact, but as a constitutive dimension of scholarly work itself.

This point is especially significant because academic writing is not reducible to the production of grammatically correct or stylistically polished text. In many fields, writing functions as an epistemic practice through which arguments are refined, interpretations are developed, and theoretical contributions take shape. When GenAI is used beyond limited supportive tasks, the central issue is therefore not simply whether content has been assisted, but whether the human researcher remains intellectually present in the processes of reasoning, judgement, and justification that underpin scholarly knowledge.

Critical perspectives further warn that the automation of editorial and evaluative processes risks displacing professional judgement and eroding the human work of peer review and academic evaluation (Gendron et al., 2022; França & Monserrat, 2024; Lund & Naheem, 2023). Reviews of AI use in scholarly publishing similarly emphasise that automated tools may support screening, efficiency, or preliminary organisation, but cannot substitute interpretive expertise, contextual evaluation, or accountable editorial and peer-review judgement (Kousha & Thelwall, 2023; Misra & Chandwar, 2023). What is at stake, therefore, is not only the reliability of AI outputs but the preservation of the human interpretive authority on which scholarly legitimacy depends.

From this standpoint, human–AI complementarity should not be understood as a simple division of labour between a productive machine and a supervising human. Rather, it requires a normative boundary: AI may assist scholarly work, but it cannot assume responsibility for the epistemic and ethical acts through which knowledge claims are formulated, defended, and validated. Ethical governance of GenAI must therefore prioritise the preservation of human interpretive authority, reflexive judgement, and accountability across the entire research and publishing lifecycle

3. Methodology

3.1 Review Design

This study employs an integrative narrative review complemented by conceptual synthesis. This design is particularly appropriate for examining emerging, conceptually diffuse, and rapidly evolving phenomena such as GenAI in academic writing and scholarly publishing, where empirical evidence, normative arguments, policy documents, and editorial reflections coexist but are rarely brought together within a single analytical framework (Whittemore & Knafl, 2005; Lubbe, Ham-Baloyi & Smit, 2020). Unlike systematic reviews, which typically prioritise exhaustiveness and narrowly defined research questions, integrative narrative reviews allow for the critical synthesis of heterogeneous sources. They are especially suitable for theory building, conceptual clarification, and the identification of ethical and governance implications across domains. This approach is therefore well suited to the present study, which examines AI-related issues at the intersection of research practice, editorial governance, and publishing systems (Whittemore & Knafl, 2005; Lubbe et al., 2020).



3.2 Data Corpus and Source Selection

The review draws on a broad corpus of scholarly literature on GenAI in academic research and publishing. The initial corpus comprised peer-reviewed articles, review papers, and editorials addressing GenAI in relation to academic publishing, research integrity, peer review, and editorial decision-making. Sources spanned multiple disciplines, including medicine, management, tourism, marketing, ethics, linguistics, education, information systems, law, psychology, engineering, and publishing studies. This disciplinary breadth reflects the cross-cutting nature of GenAI and ensures that ethical and governance issues are examined beyond any single epistemic tradition (Dwivedi et al., 2023; Gendron et al., 2022; Lund et al., 2023).

Relevant literature was identified through structured searches conducted in the Scopus database, selected for its broad coverage of peer-reviewed journals across disciplines. Searches were carried out up to 2025 using the following search string applied to titles, abstracts, and keywords: ["generative artificial intelligence" OR "ChatGPT" OR "AI"] AND ["research integrity" OR "editorial policy" OR "publishing ethics"]. This initial search yielded 1,833 documents. A series of filters was then applied to refine the corpus: limiting results to English-language publications reduced the sample to 1,779 documents; restricting document types to articles, reviews, and editorials reduced it further to 999 records, excluding conference papers, book chapters, books, conference reviews, errata, notes, letters, short surveys, retracted items, and data papers. A further thematic refinement based on relevant keywords related to ethics, AI ethics, artificial intelligence governance, editorial policies, decision-making, research integrity, editorial processes, and responsible AI narrowed the working corpus to 331 documents.

In the final stage, these 331 records were examined in greater depth to assess their substantive relevance to the aims of the study. Ultimately, 62 publications were selected for inclusion on the basis of their direct engagement with the ethical, epistemic, educational, or editorial implications of GenAI. This final corpus provided sufficient analytical depth to support the development of a coherent conceptual framework addressing ethical challenges, governance orientations, and responsibility allocation across the research and publishing lifecycle.

3.3 Analytical Procedure

The analytical process followed an iterative, reflexive, and interpretive procedure consistent with integrative narrative review methodology. All included sources were read in full and subjected to open thematic coding to identify recurring concerns, normative claims, empirical findings, and policy positions related to GenAI in scholarly research and publishing. Coding was inductive and concept-driven, allowing themes to emerge from the literature rather than being imposed a priori (Whittemore & Knafl, 2005; Braun & Clarke, 2006). Initial codes included, among others, authorship and responsibility, transparency and disclosure, originality and plagiarism, automation and deskilling, editorial judgement, detection technologies, peer review practices, and governance mechanisms.

In a second stage, these initial codes were iteratively clustered into higher-order analytical categories through constant comparison across disciplines, publication types, and normative perspectives. This comparative process enabled the identification of shared patterns and points of divergence in how ethical challenges associated with GenAI are conceptualised and addressed across scholarly contexts. It resulted in three broad conceptual groupings that structure the analysis presented in this paper: (1) ethical and responsible practices grounded in human oversight and accountability; (2) persistent grey zones in which norms, policies, and practices remain unsettled or contested; and (3) unethical practices associated with GenAI.

A third stage involved conceptual synthesis, during which empirical findings, editorial reflections, and policy-oriented arguments were integrated to articulate broader ethical principles and governance implications. Rather than seeking artificial consensus, particular attention was paid to tensions, ambiguities, and disagreements within the literature, as these illuminate the limitations of existing policies and underscore the need for context-sensitive, human-centred governance frameworks. This emphasis on interpretation and theory building reflects the central aim of integrative narrative reviews: to move beyond aggregation toward conceptual clarification and normative insight (Torraco, 2005; Snyder, 2019).

Editorial perspectives were treated as forms of expert knowledge that help reveal how ethical principles are operationalised in real-world publishing contexts. This made it possible to examine the conceptual framework against actual editorial decision-making practices, particularly in situations where formal policies provide only limited guidance. The authors' own research and editorial experience informed this interpretive process as an analytical resource consistent with integrative review methodology.

4. Results

4.1 Ethical Challenges of GenAI in Scholarly Research

GenAI presents a set of ethical challenges that extend beyond isolated cases of misuse, affecting the foundational assumptions of scholarly research. The literature consistently indicates that these challenges cluster around authorship and responsibility, originality and trust, transparency and disclosure, peer review integrity, and the systemic effects of automation within academic publishing.



4.2 Authorship, Responsibility, and Moral Agency

One of the most widely discussed ethical challenges concerns the status of AI-assisted scholarship. While GenAI systems can produce fluent academic text, they lack moral agency, intentionality, and accountability. As a result, there is a general consensus that AI cannot be recognised as an author and that full responsibility for all content must remain with human authors (Lund & Naheem, 2023; Misra & Chandwar, 2023; Moffatt & Hall, 2025).

However, denying AI authorship does not fully resolve the ethical problem. When AI systems are used to generate substantive text, arguments, or analytical structures, epistemic and intellectual responsibility may become blurred. (Gendron et al., 2022). Empirical and conceptual analyses suggest that as AI assumes greater roles in analytical framing and argument generation, human responsibility becomes increasingly difficult to separate from automated outputs (Dogru et al., 2023; Kousha & Thelwall, 2023; Lund & Naheem, 2023). This challenge is especially critical in interpretive and theory-driven research, where reasoning processes themselves constitute a central scholarly contribution and cannot be reduced to algorithmic patterning.

4.3 Originality, Plagiarism, and the Reliability of Academic Publications

GenAI challenges established understandings of originality and plagiarism by enabling the synthetic recombination of existing texts without direct textual similarity. This challenges plagiarism detection systems designed to identify verbatim copying rather than probabilistic text generation (Guleria et al., 2023; Matsubara & Matsubara, 2025).

A particularly serious concern is the phenomenon of hallucinated or fabricated references. A growing body of empirical and editorial research documents cases in which GenAI systems produce plausible but non-existent citations, misattribute sources, or combine elements of real references into fabricated ones. These practices pose direct risks to the reliability, verifiability, and traceability of scholarly research, especially when AI-generated references are accepted uncritically by authors (Ateriya et al., 2025). When such errors, along with fabricated or manipulated data, are not detected before submission, they undermine trust in the academic record and shift the burden of verification disproportionately onto reviewers and editors, thereby straining peer review processes and increasing the likelihood that erroneous or unverifiable claims enter the published literature (Gendron et al., 2022; Kousha & Thelwall, 2023).

4.4 Transparency, Disclosure, and Uneven Norms

Transparency regarding the use of AI is widely promoted as a core ethical principle, yet disclosure practices remain uneven. While many journals now require authors to declare AI assistance, evidence suggests that AI is often used without disclosure, either because of uncertainty about expectations or fear of negative editorial consequences (Yin et al., 2025).

The literature highlights that disclosure alone is insufficient as an ethical safeguard. Overly formalistic disclosure statements may provide little insight into how AI has shaped the research process. On the other hand, inconsistent enforcement risks creating uneven norms across journals and disciplines (Yin et al., 2025). Ethical transparency, therefore, requires not only disclosure but also meaningful contextualisation of AI's role in scholarly work.

4.5 Peer Review, Confidentiality, and Automation Bias

A particularly sensitive area in this debate concerns the use of GenAI in peer review, where questions of confidentiality, judgment, and procedural integrity become especially pronounced. The use of GenAI in peer review introduces distinct ethical and governance challenges. Reviewers may be tempted to use AI tools to summarise manuscripts, draft evaluative comments, or assist in assessing methodological quality and originality. However, submitting unpublished manuscripts, bound to the principle of confidentiality, to external AI systems raises significant concerns regarding confidentiality, data protection, intellectual property, and the integrity of the review process, particularly when the data retention and secondary use practices of AI platforms remain opaque (Doskaliuk et al., 2025; Lund et al., 2023).

Beyond confidentiality risks, reliance on AI-generated evaluations raises concerns about automation bias, particularly when expert interpretation and judgement are expected (Gendron et al., 2022; Kousha & Thelwall, 2023; Assaf et al., 2025). As a result, the literature consistently emphasises that evaluative judgement in peer review and editorial decision-making must remain a non-delegable human responsibility.

4.6 Systemic Effects: Automation, Deskilling, and Publishing Cultures

Beyond individual practices, GenAI raises systemic ethical concerns about automation and deskilling in the scholarly publishing sector. According to Braverman (1998) and Gendron et al. (2022), deskilling refers to the process through which human expertise, judgement, and professional competence are progressively eroded as tasks are transferred to automated systems or technologies, reducing opportunities for skill development and accountable decision-making. Critical analyses warn that increasing reliance on AI-driven tools for manuscript screening, reviewer selection, and editorial decision support may gradually displace human judgment, weaken professional expertise, and transform publishing into a more technocratic and metric-driven enterprise.



(Gendron et al., 2022; Kousha & Thelwall, 2023; Assaf et al., 2025). Editorial reflections further note that such shifts risk narrowing evaluative criteria and privileging efficiency and standardisation over contextual interpretation and expert judgement, particularly in disciplines that rely on qualitative reasoning and theoretical contribution (Lund et al., 2023; Linardon et al., 2025). These developments intersect with existing performance pressures in academia, such as the “publish or perish” culture and quantitative evaluation regimes. In such environments, GenAI may incentivise speed and volume over reflection and depth, amplifying inequalities and privileging those with greater access to advanced tools (França & Monserrat, 2024; Arar, Alsharif & Zaidan, 2025).

These ethical challenges demonstrate that GenAI is not merely a neutral productivity tool but a socio-technical intervention that reshapes scholarly norms, responsibilities, and power relations. Addressing these challenges, therefore, requires governance approaches that move beyond technical compliance and reaffirm the centrality of human judgement, accountability, and ethical reflexivity in scholarly research.

4.7 Systematisation of Practices

Building on the ethical challenges identified, we now systematise practices associated with GenAI in academic research. The literature supports a differentiated approach that distinguishes among ethically acceptable and responsible practices, persistent grey zones in which norms and policies remain unsettled, and clearly unethical practices. This systematisation reflects a context-sensitive governance logic that is increasingly advocated across disciplines and publishing contexts (Samuel et al., 2021; Arar et al., 2025; Yin et al., 2025).

4.7.1 Ethical and Responsible Practices

The use of GenAI characterises ethical and responsible practices in AI-assisted academic research as a supportive instrument operating under sustained human oversight, transparency, and accountability. Across disciplines, the literature converges on the principle that responsibility for scholarly decisions—including interpretation, argumentation, and validation—must remain with human authors, regardless of the degree of AI assistance employed (Kaeznick et al., 2023; Yin et al., 2025; Lund et al., 2023).

Responsible AI use, therefore, requires authors to retain control over all intellectual judgments, critically verify AI-assisted outputs, and ensure that generative systems do not substitute for epistemic reasoning, methodological choice, or theoretical development (Kaeznick et al., 2023; Safrai & Orwig, 2024). Empirical studies consistently show that GenAI lacks the contextual understanding, critical reasoning, and disciplinary judgement required for core scholarly tasks (Safrai & Orwig, 2024; Jiang et al., 2025). Ethical use is thus conditional on AI remaining subordinate to human expertise.

In editorial and peer-review contexts, ethical practice further entails respecting confidentiality, avoiding automation bias, and maintaining human evaluative authority. Editorial guidelines and publishing studies emphasise that AI tools may assist with administrative screening or language-related tasks, but must not replace judgement-based functions such as manuscript evaluation, reviewer assessment, or editorial decision-making (Lund et al., 2023; Kousha & Thelwall, 2023; Mollaki, 2024). Transparency regarding the use of AI by authors, reviewers, and editors is widely regarded as a necessary condition for accountability; however, it is not, on its own, sufficient to guarantee ethical integrity (Yin et al., 2025; Miao et al., 2025).

Ethical AI practices, therefore, are those that enhance efficiency or accessibility without displacing epistemic responsibility, reinforce rather than erode trust in scholarly communication, and remain embedded within institutional norms of accountability and governance (Table 3).

Table 3. Ethical and responsible practices for GenAI use

Domain	Practice	Ethical rationale	Key references
Academic writing	Language editing and readability improvement	Enhances clarity and accessibility without altering the intellectual content or displacing the author's responsibility for arguments and claims.	Safrai & Orwig (2024); Lund et al. (2023); Yin et al. (2025)
Research preparation	Brainstorming and exploratory assistance	Supports ideation and hypothesis generation while keeping interpretive, theoretical, and methodological decisions under human control.	Jiang et al. (2025); Hansen et al. (2025); Assaf et al. (2025)
Transparency	Explicit disclosure of AI use and scope	Enables editors, reviewers, and readers to assess the responsibility, accountability, and potential epistemic risks associated with AI assistance.	Yin et al. (2025); Kaeznick et al. (2023); Moffatt & Hall (2025)
Editorial processes	AI-assisted screening with human oversight	Improves efficiency in administrative or technical checks while preserving human judgment in evaluative and decision-making roles.	Lund et al. (2023); Kousha & Thelwall (2023); Mollaki (2024)
Education and training	Guided AI use with explicit ethical instruction	Builds AI literacy and awareness of responsibility, reducing misuse and reinforcing norms of academic integrity.	Dwivedi et al. (2023); Miao et al. (2025); Yin et al. (2025)

Source: authors’ own elaboration.



4.7.2 Persistent Grey Zones and Unsettled Practices

Between clearly unethical practices and clearly ethical, responsible uses lies a broad and persistent grey zone in which norms remain contested, operational guidance is limited, and ethical risk varies by context. Practices within this zone are not inherently unethical. Still, they raise heightened concerns depending on disciplinary epistemologies, the stage of the research or publication process, and the degree to which GenAI substitutes for or shapes human judgment. Empirical analyses of journal policies and editorial practices demonstrate continuing uncertainty regarding acceptable levels of AI contribution, the appropriate granularity of disclosure, and the legitimacy of AI use in peer review and evaluation (Yin et al., 2025; Mollaki, 2024; Kaebnick et al., 2023).

Grey zones are particularly salient in interpretive, qualitative, and interdisciplinary research, where the boundary between technical assistance and intellectual contribution is difficult to formalise. In such contexts, GenAI may influence framing, synthesis, or evaluative judgment in ways that are neither fully transparent nor easily attributable. Editorial responses to these cases rarely rely on strict rules; instead, they emphasise proportionality, dialogue, and case-by-case assessment grounded in disciplinary norms and editorial judgement (Kaebnick et al., 2023; Assaf et al., 2025).

Importantly, the persistence of grey zones alone does not signal regulatory failure. Rather, it reflects the structural mismatch between generalised AI policies and the situated nature of scholarly judgement. Detection tools, disclosure mandates, and categorical prohibitions offer limited guidance when responsibility is distributed across humans and systems. As a result, grey zones must be governed not through rigid permission or prohibition, but through context-sensitive judgement that consistently re-anchors responsibility in human actors and institutions (Mollaki, 2024; Miao et al., 2025) (see table 4).

Table 4. Grey zones in GenAI use

Issue	Description	Ethical tension	Key references
Depth of AI contribution	Unclear limit at which AI assistance becomes a substantive intellectual contribution.	Assistance vs authorship and accountability; difficulty assigning responsibility for ideas and interpretations.	Lund et al. (2023); Moffatt & Hall (2025); Kaebnick et al. (2023)
Depth of disclosure	Minimal statements vs detailed reporting of AI use and scope.	Transparency vs feasibility; excessive disclosure burdens vs insufficient accountability.	Yin et al. (2025); Kaebnick et al. (2023); Hansen et al. (2025)
AI use in peer review	Limited AI assistance for summarisation, language, or drafting reviewer comments.	Efficiency vs confidentiality and evaluative integrity; automation bias risks.	Mollaki (2024); Yin et al. (2025); Kousha & Thelwall (2023)
Reliance on detection tools	Use of AI detectors to screen submissions or inform editorial decisions.	Screening efficiency vs false positives, opacity, and trust erosion.	Matsubara & Matsubara (2025); Odeh et al. (2025); Hansen et al. (2025)

Source: authors’ own elaboration.

4.7.3 Unethical Practices in AI-Assisted Academic Research

Unethical practices in AI-assisted academic research are characterised by deception, misrepresentation, abdication of epistemic responsibility, or direct harm to the integrity of the scholarly record. The literature converges on the view that such practices constitute research misconduct or serious breaches of publication ethics, irrespective of whether GenAI tools were used deliberately, opportunistically, or under conditions of ambiguous guidance, a position increasingly articulated in editor-led integrity guidelines (Gandhi et al., 2025; Hansen et al., 2025; Kaebnick et al., 2023; Mollaki, 2024; Yin et al., 2025).

Crucially, the unethical status of these practices does not arise from the use of AI per se, but from the way it is deployed to fabricate knowledge, obscure human responsibility, or bypass essential scholarly judgement. Across disciplines, editors and research integrity scholars consistently reject practices in which GenAI replaces core epistemic functions such as data interpretation, theoretical reasoning, or evaluative judgement (Mollaki, 2024; Safrai & Orwig, 2024; Yin et al., 2025) (see table 5).

**Table 5.** Unethical practices associated with GenAI in academic research

Category of practice	Description	Why is it unethical	Key references
Undisclosed AI-generated text submission	Submitting AI-generated or substantially AI-written text as human-authored without disclosure.	Constitutes deception and misrepresentation; obscures accountability for claims and errors; undermines trust in authorship and peer review.	Kaebnick et al. (2023); Yin et al. (2025); Lund et al. (2023)
Fabrication or hallucination of references	Inclusion of non-existent, incorrect, or unverifiable references generated by AI systems.	Introduces false knowledge into the scholarly record; no accountable epistemic source; violates norms of verifiability and traceability.	Safrai & Orwig (2024); Hansen et al. (2025); Linardon et al. (2025)
AI-generated data analysis or interpretation without human oversight	Delegating statistical reasoning, causal inference, or interpretation of results to AI without expert validation.	Abdication of epistemic responsibility; AI lacks domain understanding and cannot justify analytical choices or bear responsibility for error.	Assaf et al. (2025); Yin et al. (2025); Jiang et al. (2025)
Production of entire manuscripts or reviews by AI	Generating full articles or reviews with minimal human intellectual contribution beyond prompting or surface editing.	Reduces scholarship to automated text production; conceals responsibility for argumentation, originality, and ethical compliance.	Safrai & Orwig (2024); Moffatt & Hall (2025); Kaebnick et al. (2023)
Undisclosed AI use in peer review or editorial evaluation	Using AI tools to draft peer-review reports or editorial judgments without transparency.	Compromises confidentiality, evaluative integrity, and trust; reviewers and editors remain accountable but outsource judgment to non-accountable systems.	Mollaki (2024); Yin et al. (2025); Kousha & Thelwall (2023)
Delegation of ethical or methodological judgement to AI	Relying on AI to assess ethical compliance, research design adequacy, or methodological validity.	Ethical and methodological judgment requires moral agency and contextual reasoning; responsibility cannot be transferred to AI.	Kaebnick et al. (2023); Miao et al. (2025)
Intentional evasion of editorial scrutiny or detection	Editing AI-generated text to evade AI detectors or mislead editors and reviewers.	Constitutes deliberate deception; weaponises AI opacity to bypass governance safeguards.	Matsubara & Matsubara (2025); Odeh, Salameh & Elrefae (2025)
Attribution of authorship or co-authorship to AI systems	Listing AI tools as authors or co-authors on scholarly publications.	Violates authorship criteria grounded in accountability, responsibility, and moral agency; no responsible agent can be held accountable.	Lund et al. (2023); Kaebnick et al. (2023); Moffatt & Hall (2025)

Source: authors' own elaboration.

5. Discussion

This study aims to move beyond binary debates about whether GenAI should be permitted in scholarly work, and instead to clarify how ethical boundaries are being constructed in practice and what this implies for editorial governance and research integrity. Across the corpus, three consistent patterns emerge. First, ethical risk is driven by responsibility diffusion, the ways AI-mediated workflows can obscure who is accountable for claims, interpretations, and evaluative decisions (Kaebnick et al., 2023; Moffatt & Hall, 2025). Second, while policies converge on a few baseline principles, they diverge sharply in operational detail, leaving substantial discretion and burden on reviewers and editors, especially concerning the control and judgment of AI use (Lund et al., 2023; Yin et al., 2025). Third, the most persistent governance challenge is the grey zone, where AI can eventually support writing and review tasks while still shaping intellectual contributions in ways that are hard to attribute, disclose, and evaluate (Mollaki, 2024; Yin et al., 2025).

A central contribution of this systematisation is its distinction between ethical and responsible uses, persistent grey zones and unethical practices, aligning with how the most authoritative sources define the ethical dangers: AI systems cannot bear responsibility, and therefore cannot serve as moral agents in authorship or evaluation (Kaebnick et al., 2023; Moffatt & Hall, 2025). This helps explain why the corpus consistently treats certain practices as misconduct, especially when AI enables deception (e.g., undisclosed AI-written text), fabrication (e.g., hallucinated citations), or substitution of epistemic judgement (e.g., unverified AI-driven interpretation) (Hansen et al., 2025; Safrai & Orwig, 2024).

Empirical work reinforces this normative position by showing a persistent asymmetry: AI outputs may be fluent and persuasive but can still fail in critical reasoning and epistemic reliability, making human validation indispensable (Jiang et al., 2025; Safrai & Orwig, 2024). The result is a governance implication that spans the corpus: responsible use necessitates active human epistemic control, not merely procedural human oversight (Kaebnick et al., 2023; Dwivedi et al., 2023).

The paper's findings also resonate with policy-mapping studies, which show partial convergence at the level of principles (no AI authorship, disclosure, and human accountability) but substantial divergence in specificity and enforcement (Lund et al., 2023; Yin et al., 2025). Yin et al. (2025), for example, demonstrate that many journal policies remain under-specified on consequential issues, including whether and how AI may be used. This helps explain why editors frequently resort to proportionality and case-by-case reasoning rather than rule-based decision-making, particularly when policy language is general and disciplinary stakes vary (Kaebnick et al., 2023; Assaf et al., 2025).



This pattern is consistent with system-level governance perspectives that view integrity management as a multi-actor, adaptive process rather than one determined by rules. The "grey zone" is not simply an absence of policy; it is a predictable outcome when institutional rules interact with rapidly changing tools, heterogeneous epistemic norms, and unequal capacities for verification (Miao et al., 2025; Dwivedi et al., 2023).

A central implication of the study is that grey zones are structural. Even with disclosure, it can be challenging to determine when AI support constitutes an intellectual contribution, particularly in interpretive research where writing is inextricably linked to theorising and sense-making. Particularly instructive in this regard are the tourism and management editorials included in the corpus, which operationalise an epistemic-impact logic by discouraging AI use in conceptual and interpretive sections while allowing limited assistance for language and mechanical tasks. This contrasts with more general disclosure-focused policies, which assume that transparency alone is adequate for governance (Yin et al., 2025). Taken together, these features support the argument that ethical governance cannot be reduced to permitted/prohibited rules; it requires evaluative attention to how AI affects the epistemic work of research.

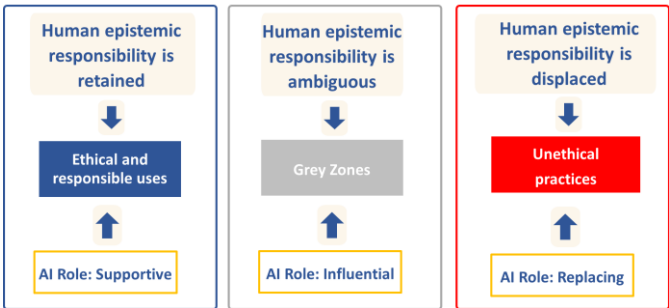
Across the corpus, peer review appears to be the most fragile point in the scholarly integrity system under GenAI, as it combines confidentiality and evaluative judgment constraints. The literature reviewed here consistently suggests that using external AI systems in review workflows can violate confidentiality, create data leakage risks, and introduce automation bias into the judgment of human responsibility (Mollaki, 2024; Lund et al., 2023). The framework proposed here helps reconcile these positions: AI support is ethically defensible when it does not displace accountability for evaluation and when confidentiality and transparency requirements are met; it becomes ethically risky when it replaces judgment or obscures responsibility for review claims (Mollaki, 2024; Yin et al., 2025).

A recurring tension in editorial governance is the temptation to outsource enforcement to AI detectors. The corpus provides strong reasons to resist this. Detection research shows that classification is sensitive to editing and style mimicry, making detector outputs unstable as a basis for ethical decisions (Matsubara et al., 2025). Even when detection models claim high accuracy under specific conditions, the broader governance problem remains: treating detector scores as ethical evidence risks false positives, erodes trust, and incentivises an arms race of evasion and counter-detection (Odeh et al., 2025; Hansen et al., 2025). The results align with the editorial literature's implicit conclusion: detection tools may be useful for triage, but they cannot substitute responsibility-based judgement, and they should not be treated as dispositive evidence of misconduct (Kousha & Thelwall, 2023; Matsubara et al., 2025).

6. Conclusion and Implications

In conclusion, this paper has addressed its three aims by first clarifying the ethical challenges posed by GenAI across research, peer review, and editorial decision-making, particularly those related to responsibility diffusion, transparency, confidentiality, and the reliability of the scholarly record. Second, it has offered a differentiated systematisation of AI-assisted scholarly practices, distinguishing between responsible uses, contested grey zones, and integrity-compromising practices, thereby moving beyond reductive permissive/prohibitive framings. Third, it has advanced a human-centred, context-sensitive governance perspective in which the ethical use of GenAI depends on preserving human epistemic authority, reflexive judgement, and accountability throughout the research and publishing lifecycle. These findings are synthesised in the responsibility-centred theoretical model presented in Figure 1, which translates the paper's core argument into an analytical framework. The model formalises the central claim that the ethical status of GenAI use depends not simply on whether AI is involved, but on how that involvement affects the retention or displacement of human epistemic responsibility. In this framework, AI participation is understood functionally as supportive, influential, or replacing, allowing the model to explain why similar applications may be ethically acceptable in one context yet problematic in another. Figure 1, therefore, reinforces the paper's broader conclusion that binary or compliance-based approaches to governance are inadequate, because what matters ethically is the extent to which human responsibility for interpretation, judgment, and accountability remains intact.

Figure 1: Responsibility-centred theoretical model



Source: Own elaboration.



The model also shows that grey zones should not be understood as temporary anomalies, but as a structural feature of AI-mediated research. They arise when AI substantially influences framing, synthesis, or evaluative emphasis without fully replacing human judgment, thereby making the attribution of responsibility more difficult in practice. As Figure 1 suggests, these cases resist simple rule-based assessment and instead call for proportional, context-sensitive editorial judgement grounded in disciplinary epistemologies and institutional accountability.

6.1 Theoretical Implications

The study advances theory in three important ways. First, it reframes AI ethics in scholarly research as a problem of responsibility allocation, rather than as a question of technical compliance or text provenance. This shift offers a more comprehensive explanation of why current policy responses, such as authorship bans, disclosure mandates, and detection systems, are necessary but insufficient.

Second, the responsibility-centred model offers a unifying theoretical framework that integrates authorship, peer review, and editorial governance. By doing so, it moves beyond fragmented treatments of AI ethics that focus narrowly on author behaviour and instead conceptualises scholarly publishing as an interconnected epistemic system.

Third, by theorising editorial judgement as a form of epistemic institutional capacity, the paper contributes to governance theory in publishing. Editorial decision-making is not treated as discretionary enforcement of rules, but as a central mechanism for managing ethical ambiguity in contexts where responsibility cannot be fully codified. This reconceptualisation helps explain why human judgement remains indispensable even as AI capabilities expand.

6.2 Practical Implications

The findings of this study have direct practical relevance for multiple stakeholders involved in scholarly communication. For editors and publishers, the analysis underscores the limitations of relying solely on technical solutions such as AI-detection tools or standardised disclosure statements. Instead, the study highlights the need to strengthen editorial judgement as a core governance resource. This includes developing discipline-sensitive policies, providing guidance rather than purely punitive responses in ambiguous cases, and supporting editors in making proportional, context-aware decisions.

For reviewers, the study clarifies ethical expectations for the use of AI in the peer-review process. Uploading manuscripts under review to external AI platforms is ethically problematic because it may compromise confidentiality, data protection, and the integrity of the evaluative process. Peer review should therefore remain grounded in human judgement, even where limited AI-assisted administrative support may be permitted under explicit governance conditions.

For researchers and authors, the implications are also significant. The study underscores the importance of maintaining intellectual ownership over analytical decisions, interpretations, and theoretical claims, even when AI tools are employed ethically. Transparency about AI use should be accompanied by reflective engagement with how AI has shaped the research process, rather than being reduced to minimal compliance. This perspective promotes more responsible and trustworthy scholarly practices while enabling researchers to leverage the benefits of AI.

At an institutional and systemic level, the findings suggest that responsible AI governance requires investment in ethical literacy, editorial training, and supportive infrastructures, rather than an exclusive focus on surveillance and enforcement. Universities, journals, and professional associations can use the conceptual distinctions outlined in this paper to develop policies and educational initiatives that strike a balance between technical innovation and integrity.

These practical implications point towards a more human-centred model of academic publishing, in which GenAI is used to enhance accessibility and efficiency, while responsibility, judgement, and trust remain firmly anchored in human expertise. Based on the findings, the authors' editorial experience, and as a practice-oriented implication of this study, we propose an author checklist for the responsible use of GenAI (see Appendix 1), which may be useful for both authors and journals. The *Tourism & Management Studies* journal will also adopt this checklist.

6.3 Limitations and Future Research

This study is subject to some limitations. As an integrative narrative review with conceptual synthesis, it is intended to offer theoretical clarification rather than empirical measurement or statistical generalisation. The fast-moving nature of GenAI governance also means that policies and practices may evolve more quickly than the published literature can capture.

Future research should examine how the model presented performs in practice across different fields, publication cultures, and journal settings with particular attention to whether its distinctions between supportive, influential, and replacing forms of AI use can be applied consistently. Comparative and qualitative studies involving authors, reviewers, and editors would be especially useful for understanding how responsibility is negotiated in concrete cases and for assessing whether current governance mechanisms are adequate to manage the ethical complexity of AI-mediated research.



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Appendix 1: Author Checklist for Responsible Use of Generative AI

A. Disclosure and Transparency

Have generative AI tools been used in this manuscript?

- ☐ Yes (proceed answering)
☐ No (just sign the document)

If yes, please describe how and where AI was used:

☐ I declare that no generative AI assistance has been intentionally concealed from the journal.

B. Human Epistemic Responsibility

- ☐ All intellectual decisions—including interpretation, argumentation, theoretical framing, and conclusions—were made by the authors.
- ☐ All AI-assisted outputs were critically reviewed and independently verified by the authors.

C. Boundaries of Acceptable AI Use

- ☐ Generative AI was not used to replace epistemic reasoning, methodological choice, or theoretical development.
- ☐ All references were independently checked and correspond to real, verifiable sources.

D. Authorship and Accountability

- ☐ All listed authors meet authorship criteria and accept responsibility for the integrity of the work.

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- ☐ I am willing to provide further clarification on AI use if requested by the editors.

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I confirm that any use of generative AI in this manuscript adheres to the principles of transparency, accountability, and human epistemic responsibility.

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